

WEST BENGAL ORIGIN

Begun Basanti

Eggplant in Golden Mustard-Yogurt Sauce

A Dish Named for Spring

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Begun Basanti

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Begun Basanti

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Color of Spring on a Plate

"Basanti" takes its name from Basant, the Bengali word for spring, and specifically evokes the bright yellow associated with Basant Panchami — the festival honoring Saraswati, the goddess of knowledge and the arts, celebrated with yellow clothing, yellow flowers, and yellow-hued foods across Bengal. Begun basanti, eggplant cooked in a golden mustard-yogurt sauce, belongs to this small but beloved category of "basanti" dishes defined as much by color as by flavor.

The dish achieves its signature golden hue through a combination of turmeric and a mustard-yogurt paste, giving the eggplant a glossy, warmly colored coating that visually signals celebration on the Bengali table — food that looks like spring, appropriate for Saraswati Puja and other joyful spring occasions, much as basanti pulao, the rice counterpart in this same collection, serves a similar symbolic role.

Beyond its festive associations, begun basanti has also become a well-loved dish in everyday Bengali cooking, prized simply for how well eggplant absorbs the tangy, mildly sweet mustard-yogurt sauce — proof that a dish born from festival symbolism can just as easily earn its place at an ordinary family dinner.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Color of Spring on a Plate, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Named for Basant (spring) and closely associated with Basant Panchami and Saraswati Puja, festivals celebrated with yellow-themed foods and clothing. Part of a small category of "basanti" dishes in Bengali cuisine, defined by their golden-yellow color. A dish that bridges festive and everyday cooking, equally at home at a Saraswati Puja feast or a regular family dinner. Represents the Bengali culinary tradition of using color symbolically to mark seasons and celebrations.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	25m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Small blender or mortar and pestle, for the mustard paste
- Kadai or wide pan
- Wooden spoon

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Begun basanti keeps refrigerated for up to 2 days — like other mustard-yogurt based dishes, it's best enjoyed relatively fresh, as the flavors and texture are at their peak shortly after cooking. Reheat gently over low heat to avoid splitting the yogurt-based sauce.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Eggplant, cut into thick rounds or wedges	1 lb	450 g	1 lb
Plain yogurt	½ cup	120 g	½ katori
Mustard seeds	1 tbsp	10 g	1 chammach
Turmeric powder	1 tsp	3 g	1 chammach
Green chilies	2–3	2–3	2–3
Mustard oil	4 tbsp	60 ml	4 chammach
Nigella seeds (kalonji)	¼ tsp	1 g	¼ chammach
Sugar	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste
Water	¼ cup	60 ml	¼ katori

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Any variety of eggplant works well, though the smaller, rounder Indian eggplant is traditional if available at South Asian grocers — regular globe eggplant is a completely acceptable substitute. Use full-fat, plain yogurt for the best texture and tang; low-fat versions can split more easily during cooking. As with the other mustard-based dishes in this collection, soaking the mustard seeds before grinding is important for a smooth paste.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Eggplant and Paste

01 SALT THE EGGPLANT

Lightly salt the cut eggplant pieces and let them sit for 15 minutes — this draws out excess moisture and any bitterness, then pat dry before cooking.

02 MAKE THE MUSTARD PASTE

Soak the mustard seeds in warm water for 20 minutes, then grind with the green chilies to a smooth paste.

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Preparing the Eggplant and Paste, continued



03 WHISK THE YOGURT

Whisk the yogurt smooth in a bowl, then combine it with the mustard paste and turmeric, mixing until fully incorporated into a smooth, golden marinade base.

Chef tip. whisking the yogurt smooth before combining with other ingredients prevents lumps in the final sauce.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Preparing the Eggplant and Paste, continued

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The yogurt-mustard mixture should be smooth and a vivid golden-yellow color from the turmeric — this is the base that will coat the eggplant.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Eggplant

04 FRY THE EGGPLANT

Heat mustard oil in a kadai and shallow-fry the eggplant pieces until golden brown on both sides, about 4–5 minutes per side. Remove and set aside.

05 TEMPER THE NIGELLA SEEDS

In the remaining oil, add the nigella seeds, letting them sizzle for a few seconds.



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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Cooking the Eggplant, continued

06 ADD THE YOGURT-MUSTARD MIXTURE

Reduce the heat to low before adding the yogurt-mustard mixture, stirring constantly for the first minute to prevent splitting. Add the water, sugar, and salt.

07 RETURN THE EGGPLANT AND SIMMER

Gently return the fried eggplant to the pan, spooning the sauce over each piece. Simmer on low heat for 6–8 minutes, until the sauce thickens slightly and coats the eggplant.

Color indicator. the finished dish should have a glossy, golden-yellow sauce clinging to each piece of eggplant, with no visible splitting or graininess.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Adding the yogurt mixture to a very hot pan, or letting it boil hard, is the most common cause of a split, grainy sauce. Always reduce heat to low first and stir constantly for the first minute after adding yogurt.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served with steamed rice, especially fitting for Saraswati Puja and other spring celebrations.
- A colorful, appetizing addition to a festive Bengali thali spread.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a small bowl, its golden color prominently displayed, garnished with a few whole nigella seeds.

Family Style

- A flavorful vegetarian side dish alongside dal and rice for a well-rounded, colorful family meal.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Sauce Right

- Low, gentle heat when the yogurt goes in is essential — rushing this step is the number one cause of a split sauce.
- Frying the eggplant well before adding the sauce builds flavor and helps the pieces hold their shape during the final simmer.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- The mustard-yogurt base can be mixed a few hours ahead and refrigerated, though the dish is best cooked close to serving time.
- Fry the eggplant in advance if needed, then finish with the sauce fresh just before serving.

RESTAURANT TRICK

A small pinch of ground cumin added to the sauce, though not universal, gives extra warmth that pairs nicely with the mustard's sharpness — a subtle variation worth trying.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

165 kcal	4 g	12 g	12 g	4 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Begun Basanti with Poppy Seed	some households add a touch of ground poppy seed for extra creaminess.
Doi Begun	a closely related dish with an even more yogurt-forward, less mustard-heavy sauce.
Basanti Paneer	the same golden mustard-yogurt technique applied to paneer instead of eggplant.

Why did my sauce split?

Almost always adding yogurt to oil that's too hot, or letting the sauce boil vigorously. Keep the heat low and stir constantly right after adding the yogurt mixture.

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Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I make this less tangy?

Yes — reduce the yogurt slightly and add a touch more sugar to balance the tang if you prefer a milder flavor.

Is this dish very spicy?

No — it's mild and mustard-forward rather than chili-forward. Adjust the green chilies to your preferred heat level.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Basanti	Bengali for spring, referring to the golden-yellow color associated with this style of dish.
Begun	Bengali for eggplant, the primary vegetable in this dish.
Basant Panchami	a Bengali festival honoring Saraswati, celebrated with yellow-themed foods.
Kalonji	nigella seeds, used for tempering, adding a distinctive sharp aroma.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Begun Basanti

15m	25m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

DISH

Eggplant	450 g
Plain yogurt	120 g
Mustard seeds	10 g
Turmeric powder	3 g
Green chilies	2–3
Mustard oil	60 ml
Nigella seeds	1 g
Sugar	4 g
Salt	6 g
Water	60 ml

METHOD

01 **Salt the eggplant.** Lightly salt the cut eggplant pieces and let them sit for 15 minutes — this draws out excess moisture and any bitterness, then pat dry before cooking.

02 **Make the mustard paste.** Soak the mustard seeds in warm water for 20 minutes, then grind with the green chilies to a smooth paste.

03 **Whisk the yogurt.** Whisk the yogurt smooth in a bowl, then combine it with the mustard paste and turmeric, mixing until fully incorporated into a smooth, golden marinade base.

04 **Fry the eggplant.** Heat mustard oil in a kadai and shallow-fry the eggplant pieces until golden brown on both sides, about 4–5 minutes per side.

05 **Temper the nigella seeds.** In the remaining oil, add the nigella seeds, letting them sizzle for a few seconds.

06 **Add the yogurt-mustard mixture.** Reduce the heat to low before adding the yogurt-mustard mixture, stirring constantly for the first minute to prevent splitting.

07 **Return the eggplant and simmer.** Gently return the fried eggplant to the pan, spooning the sauce over each piece.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐	Eggplant	450 g	
☐	Mustard seeds	10 g	
☐	Green chilies	2–3	
☐	Nigella seeds	1 g	
☐	Salt	6 g	
☐	Plain yogurt	120 g	
☐	Turmeric powder	3 g	
☐	Mustard oil	60 ml	
☐	Sugar	4 g	

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